

FLAMINGOS

These remarkable birds live on salty lagoons and alkaline lakes. Once classified with storks, flamingos are now thought to be related to grebes.

Extreme gregariousness defines flamingo life. These birds of the order *Phoenicopteriformes* congregate in huge flocks, sometimes numbering hundreds of thousands. These vast groups are so tightly packed that individual birds cannot easily take flight and must initially walk or run if disturbed. But the open habitat that flamingos favour, coupled with the vigilance of many birds, ensures that predators are easily spotted.

The large flocks are necessary to stimulate breeding, and flamingo courtship involves group displays. Pairs build mud nests and

territory is simply determined by how far a bird's neck will stretch from the nest. A few days after hatching, flamingo chicks gather together in large crèches. The parent birds feed their young with a liquid food called crop milk.

FILTER FEEDERS

Flamingos have a unique style of filter-feeding using a specially adapted bill. Holding its head upside-down, a flamingo strains planktonic algae and shrimps from the water through hair-like structures lining the bill. Pigments absorbed from the food give flamingos their characteristic pink colour. There are few competitors for food, as the organisms are taken from otherwise barren inland waters that are either very salty or caustic.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PHOENICOPTERIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	6



Some of the biggest flocks of flamingos are seen in the African Rift Valley, where lesser flamingos gather to feed.

CHILEAN FLAMINGO

Phoenicopus chilensis
F: *Phoenicopteridae*

The most widespread flamingo in S. America, the Chilean flamingo has a range from Peru to Tierra del Fuego, and is distinguished by grey legs with pink "knees".

1–1.3 m
3¼–4¼ ft

pinkish
white plumage

black-tipped
bill

CARIBBEAN FLAMINGO

Phoenicopus ruber
F: *Phoenicopteridae*

This Caribbean species differs from the greater flamingo in being somewhat smaller and having a pinker plumage.

extremely
long neck

pale
pink
bill

bright red
wing feathers

1.2–1.4 m
4–4½ ft

1.1–1.5 m
3½–5 ft

GREATER FLAMINGO

Phoenicopus roseus
F: *Phoenicopteridae*

With a range spanning Africa, S. Europe, and C. Asia, this is the largest and most widespread of the flamingos.

80–100 cm
32–39 in

ANDEAN FLAMINGO

Phoenicoparrus andinus
F: *Phoenicopteridae*

One of two flamingo species restricted to the higher altitudes of the Andes, this distinctively yellow-legged flamingo may wander nomadically between lakes for food.

LESSER FLAMINGO

Phoeniconaias minor
F: *Phoenicopteridae*

The smallest flamingo, this species from Africa and southern Asia occurs in huge numbers on highly alkaline lakes.

pink "knee"
is the ankle

slender grey leg

1–1.1 m
3¼–3½ ft